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Democracy Dies in Darkness

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RFK Jr.’s allies seize on vaccine fray in Fla.

State’s plan to end school shot mandates animates skeptics across the U.S.

BY **TRISHA THADANI**
AND **LAUREN WEBER**

Mack Butler was among those cheering last week as Florida Surgeon General Joseph A. Ladapo announced plans to scrap all school vaccine requirements in the state, a move that shocked health and education officials across the country but thrilled activists opposed to mandates.

Butler, a Republican state representative in Alabama, said the Sunshine State’s sweeping move gives fresh momentum to his efforts to pass legislation in his own state, where he is pushing to reduce barriers to parents claiming religious exemptions from vaccinating their kids.

“What happened in Florida is a reaction and pushback to all the lies we were told by the government during covid,” said Butler, whose bill failed to pass the legislature in Montgomery last year. “I don’t know if other states will do it — but a lot of us watch Florida.”

Ladapo’s step to unravel vaccine requirements in the third most populous state has emboldened figures across the “health freedom” movement like Butler, who hope Florida’s announcement will inspire state policymakers to keep pushing laws to loosen vaccine mandates across the country. It also won Ladapo accolades from political figures, including Trump supporter Stephen K. Bannon, who pronounced on his podcast that Ladapo would be his pick to lead the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention.

But President Donald Trump poured some cold water Friday on Ladapo’s push. “You have some vaccines that are so incredible. And I think you have to be very careful when you say that some people don’t have to be vaccinated,” the president said when asked in the Oval Office about mandates being rolled back for children. “It’s a tough stance. Look, you have vaccines that work. ... They’re not controversial at all. And I think those vaccines should be used.”

Hundreds of vaccine-related bills like Butler’s have been introduced in state legislatures across the country since the covid-19

SEE **VACCINES** ON **A17**

A songwriter had no idea that he had epilepsy, which afflicts tens of millions



CRAIG HUDSON/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

After brain surgery, the music flowed

BY **MICHAEL LARIS**

Mike Frazier performs at Bright Box Theater in Winchester, Virginia, on May 16.

The songwriter was unconscious, but his voice filled the operating room. ¶ Mike Frazier’s dirty-blond locks had been partially shaved and his head sanitized. The surgeon standing over him slid his blade in a crescent over Frazier’s right ear and tugged his scalp into position, holding it in place with a dozen sky-blue clips. ¶ Then he began opening a window into the musician’s brain. ¶ The surgeon, Lee Selznick, had chosen a Spotify playlist of Frazier’s music for the delicate procedure that would take three hours and would later marvel at the experience: “We were deep in his head, and listening to the words right out of the very part of him that was producing that beautiful music.” ¶ The task that day was to reach and remove the cause of the grievous pain that had besieged and mystified Frazier for years. After almost a decade as a folk-rock singer with a rollicking vibe and a knack for storytelling, piercing stomach pain had stymied his songwriting and drawn him

SEE **EPILEPSY** ON **A4**

Israel eases talk of annexing West Bank after UAE warning

BY **GERRY SHIH**
AND **LIOR SOROKA**

TEL AVIV — For weeks, Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu has been weighing formally annexing much or all of the occupied West Bank.

An annexation, widely viewed as a violation of international law, would inflame public opinion across the Arab world and threat-

en President Donald Trump’s first-term effort to broker peace between Israel and several of its neighbors. But it would give Netanyahu a boost with Israeli voters.

Now, an unusual message, delivered by a crucial Arab partner, is complicating his decision-making.

On Tuesday, a top Emirati official told Israeli and international

media outlets that annexation would be a “red line” for the United Arab Emirates and would “foreclose on the idea of regional integration.” The Emiratis followed the rare, coordinated interviews by special envoy Lana Nusseibeh with a flurry of back-channel warnings, according to three people with knowledge of the matter, who spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss it.

By Thursday, the people said, the issue of annexation was removed from the official agenda of a high-level consultation among Netanyahu and several senior ministers hours before it began.

An Israeli official acknowledged that the warning from the Emirates, one of the Arab countries most supportive of integrating Israel and its economy into

SEE **ISRAEL** ON **A15**

Pregnant? These chemicals in plastics can be risky.

BY **SHANNON OSAKA**,
FRANK HULLEY-JONES
AND **SIMON DUCROQUET**

When Marya Zlatnik meets with women in the early stages of pregnancy, she gives them the standard advice: Take prenatal vitamins; avoid alcohol, smoking and eating raw fish. But for certain patients, the maternal fetal medicine specialist at the University of California at San Francisco, who specializes in high-risk pregnancies, adds another warning: Avoid plastic.

That’s easier said than done. Plastic permeates Americans’ lives — it’s in furniture, food packaging, clothing, electronics and even the air. Zlatnik starts with the low-hanging fruit: Try not to eat or drink from plastic containers. Avoid heating plastic in the microwave. Stay away from highly processed foods.

Some women are receptive; others are not, overwhelmed

Phthalates are linked to problems that include premature birth, infertility and ADHD



STEPHANIE GONOT/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Phthalates are added to lotions to achieve a desired texture.

with too much information and not enough time. But for women who have had at least one premature birth, Zlatnik said, “I want them to have the information.”

She is one of a small number of medical practitioners across the country warning patients about the risk of a set of chemicals found in plastics. Known as phthalates, these compounds are found in the blood and urine of virtually everyone in the United States; nine of them are approved for use in plastics that come in close contact with food. For the past two decades, scientists have gathered growing evidence that these chemicals are linked to a dizzying array of health problems, including premature birth, infertility and ADHD. And the greatest risks — and the most dangerous outcomes — are to pregnant women and their children.

To understand how plastic

SEE **PLASTIC** ON **A10**



MARVIN JOSEPH/THE WASHINGTON POST

Thousands take to D.C.’s streets

Saturday’s “We Are All D.C.” march was one of the first major organized protests since President Donald Trump’s federal troop deployment in the nation’s capital. **Story, B18**

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